

SOP-LV-027 — Aerial Lift & Scissor Lift Safety

Safe Operation of Scissor Lifts and Boom Lifts (MEWPs) on Apex Jobsites

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TITLE	Aerial Lift & Scissor Lift Safety
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APPLIES TO	All Apex field technicians — Ontario & Manitoba
CATEGORY	Ladder & Fall Safety

1. Purpose

This procedure establishes minimum requirements for the safe operation of scissor lifts and boom lifts (Mobile Elevating Work Platforms, or MEWPs) used by Apex technicians to reach elevated work areas such as high ceilings, gymnasiums, warehouses, and atriums.

2. Scope

This SOP applies to all Apex technicians who operate, or work from, a scissor lift or boom lift on a jobsite, whether the equipment is owned, rented, or supplied by a general contractor. It applies in addition to, not instead of, the equipment manufacturer's operating manual and any site-specific rules established by the property owner or general contractor.

3. Definitions

- Scissor Lift — a vertical-lift platform enclosed by guardrails on all sides, raised and lowered on a crossed-brace (scissor) mechanism.
- Boom Lift (MEWP) — an aerial platform mounted on an articulating or telescoping boom, capable of reaching outward as well as upward.
- Exclusion Zone — the area on the ground beneath and around an operating lift, kept clear of foot traffic and vehicles while the lift is in use.
- Interlock — a safety device that prevents specific lift functions (e.g., driving while elevated) unless certain conditions are met; interlocks must never be bypassed or defeated.

4. Operator Qualification

Only technicians who have completed manufacturer-specific or CSA-recognized operator training for the class of lift being used may operate a scissor lift or boom lift. Training must be refreshed per the certifying body's schedule (typically every 3 years) or sooner if the technician has not operated that class of lift in an extended period. Supervisors confirm current certification before assigning a technician to lift work.

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5. Pre-Operation Inspection

Complete a walk-around inspection before every shift, and again if the lift has been left unattended (e.g., overnight on a multi-day job). Do not operate a lift that fails any check below — tag it out of service and report it to your supervisor.

- Tires or outriggers in good condition, correctly set and level.
- Guardrails, chains, and gate latches intact and functioning.
- Controls, emergency stop, and horn functioning correctly.
- Emergency (manual) lowering system understood and accessible.
- No visible hydraulic leaks, damaged hoses, or structural damage.
- Charge level (electric) or fuel level (engine) sufficient for the planned work.
- Load capacity plate legible and load within rated limits, including tools and materials.

6. Fall Protection in Aerial Platforms

Requirements differ by lift type:

- Scissor lifts: guardrails alone satisfy fall protection when the operator remains inside the platform with the gate closed. A harness is not required by regulation but may be required by the site's fall protection plan — confirm before starting work.
- Boom lifts (MEWPs): a full-body harness with a short (typically 6-foot or shorter, shock-absorbing) lanyard attached to the manufacturer-designated anchor point inside the basket is required at all times the platform is elevated, per SOP-LV-026.
- Never climb out of the platform, stand on guardrails, or use planks or ladders to extend reach.

7. Setup and Ground Conditions

- Confirm the surface is firm, level, and rated to support the lift's weight before raising the platform.
- Establish and barricade an exclusion zone on the ground beneath and around the lift; assign a ground spotter in occupied spaces — per SOP-LV-003, confirm occupied-space protocols with the site contact before setup.
- Check overhead clearance for lights, sprinkler heads, ductwork, and other obstructions before raising.
- Never operate within the minimum approach distance of overhead electrical lines specified by the utility or site electrician.

8. Safe Operating Practices

- Never exceed the rated load capacity, including the combined weight of occupants, tools, and materials.
- Never use a lift on a grade, slope, or surface beyond the manufacturer's rated limits.
- Never operate in wind conditions exceeding the manufacturer's rated limit (commonly 28 mph / 45 km/h for many MEWPs — confirm the specific rating on the unit).
- Never move a scissor lift while elevated unless the model is specifically rated for drive-while-elevated use.
- Never bypass, override, or disable an interlock or safety device for any reason.
- Keep hands and body inside the guardrails at all times while the platform is moving or elevated.

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9. Emergency Lowering

Every technician assigned to operate a lift must know the location and use of the manual/emergency lowering controls before raising the platform for the first time that day. If the platform controls fail while elevated, use the ground-level emergency lowering controls; if those also fail, contact your supervisor and the rental/equipment provider immediately — do not attempt to climb down from an elevated platform.

10. Prohibited Practices

Never use a lift as a material hoist beyond its rated platform capacity.

Overloading the platform — even briefly, to move materials — is one of the leading causes of tip-over incidents.

- Never allow untrained personnel to operate the controls, including from the ground-level override.
- Never leave a running or elevated lift unattended.
- Never operate a lift that is out of service or tagged for repair.

11. Incident and Near-Miss Reporting

Any tip-over, contact with an overhead obstruction, equipment malfunction, or near-miss involving a lift must be reported to your supervisor immediately and documented using the Apex Incident Report process, regardless of whether injury or damage occurred.

12. Regulatory References

- Ontario Occupational Health and Safety Act, R.S.O. 1990, c. O.1
- O. Reg. 213/91 (Construction Projects), sections 145–150 — Elevating Work Platforms
- Manitoba Workplace Safety and Health Act, C.C.S.M. c. W210
- Manitoba Workplace Safety and Health Regulation, Part 24 — Mobile Equipment
- CSA B354.2 — Self-Propelled Elevating Work Platforms
- CSA B354.6 — Boom-Supported Elevating Work Platforms (MEWPs)
- ANSI/SAIA A92.20 & A92.22 — Design, Safe Use & Training for MEWPs (reference where CSA is silent)

13. Related Apex Documents

- SOP-LV-026 — Working at Heights & Fall Protection
- SOP-LV-003 — Ontario Jobsite Health & Safety Checklist
- SOP-LV-009 — Ladder Safety — Commercial & Residential

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14. Revision History

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1.0	Jul 25, 2026	Initial release	P. Cimini

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